

Also Remember...

- Upgrading your system RAM is probably a good idea if you are going to be scanning high-resolution images. This will have a significant impact on overall scanning performance.
- Check for sRGB support. This is a new standard that makes Web images look better.
- Consider buying a transparency adapter if you plan to scan negatives, slides and transparencies directly. Automatic document feeders (ADFs) are a boon to people with large text scanning needs.
- To get good results with 35-mm slides or negatives, you should look for a special scanner that has been designed for them.
- Ensure that your printer is good enough to reproduce the high quality scans that the scanner produces.

A quick scan

The scanner, which used to be a luxury not so long ago, is now well within the reach of most people. Prices have fallen, due to competition between manufacturers and also due to the advancement of the technology used. This has put it high on the shopping lists for many home users. Today, scanner prices begin at about Rs 4,000 and offer pretty acceptable performance in terms of quality and speed. USB has helped ease the pain of installing the scanner, and increasing speed due to the higher data transfer rates it supports.

Technology Insight

The main components of a scanner are: a light sensitive diode, a light source, the lens, and the stepper motor—which moves the scan head and the mirror on which the document is placed. The light hits the document and the image is reflected back to the diodes via mirrors. The image is then focused on the CCD array, which converts photon into electrons, thus converting the image to digital format.

Smart Tips

The light source: This is either a cold cathode fluorescent lamp (CCFL) or Xenon lamp.



Xenon lamps provide better performance.

Resolution: The higher the resolution of the scanner, the sharper will be the image reproduced. Most low and mid-range scanners today have an optical (or hardware) resolution of 600 x 1,200 pixels. Here 600 is the number of CCDs or CIS (Contact Image Sensors) that are arranged in a horizontal row, and 1,200 means that the stepper motor is capable of moving in steps of 1/1200th of an inch.

Platform size: For most home users, A4 size scanners are sufficient. However, for professional uses, a scanner with an A3 sized platform is preferred.

Colour depth: 48-bit colour depth is preferred, and you should not opt for anything less than 36-bit colour depth.

Connectors: If you have a free USB port in your system then a USB scanner is the recommended choice. Parallel port scanners have lower data transfer rates, and although the SCSI models offer the fastest rate, they require you to buy special adapters.

OCR software: Most bundled OCR software offer basic functionality. For heavy text-based scanning you should look to buy third-party OCR packages, such as ABBY FineReader 6.0.

Decision Maker

	Basic use	Intermediate use	Professional use
You need	Something that you will use occasionally to scan home photos or something from a book or magazine	Something for more serious scanning, either for text documents or images	A scanner with high resolution and speeds because of large volumes of scanning
Look for	Any A4 scanner, with USB support and a minimum resolution of 600 x 1,200 dpi	Any A4 scanner with USB support and a minimum resolution of 1,200 x 2,400 dpi	A scanner with 1,600 x 3,200 dpi or better resolution, A3 platform size and preferably a SCSI interface
Our pick	UMAX Astra 2500, HP ScanJet 2300C	HP ScanJet 3500C, UMAX Astra 4700	HP ScanJet 4570C, HP ScanJet 4500,
Price range	Below Rs 5,000	Rs 5,000 to Rs 12,000	Rs 12,000 to 20,000



hp ScanJet 3500C



Scan and create family albums.

